

Geography Ch-11 (Advanced) — India's Islands: Andaman, Nicobar & Lakshadweep

Advanced / India-applied | GS-I & GS-III | Source: Majid Husain + D.R. Khullar

Bay of Bengal islands (tectonic/volcanic) vs Arabian Sea Lakshadweep (coral)

Extra CA: Great Nicobar (Galathea Bay) mega-project (distinct from Must-Do's bleaching CA)

Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH

ADVANCED — Andaman & Nicobar and Lakshadweep: Origin (Majid / Khullar)

GS-I · India
Geography →
Islands (Source:
Majid Husain,
D.R. Khullar)

■ NEWS TRIGGER

India's two island groups have contrasting origins: the Bay of Bengal Andaman & Nicobar are tectonic/volcanic, while the Arabian Sea Lakshadweep is entirely of coral origin.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

Majid: the **Andamans** are the extension of the Tertiary **Arakan Yoma** chain (sandstone, limestone, shale); the **Nicobars** are largely of **coral origin**; Lakshadweep is coral (atolls).

Andaman & Nicobar rose from submergence of surrounding low areas along the Arakan-Yoma fold belt (a major earthquake zone); Lakshadweep atolls grew on subsiding volcanic bases in the Arabian Sea.

■ KEY DATA

Group	Sea	Origin / note
Andaman Islands	Bay of Bengal	Extension of Arakan Yoma (Tertiary); sandstone/limestone/shale
Nicobar Islands	Bay of Bengal	Mainly coral origin; 18 islands (11 inhabited)
Barren Island	Bay of Bengal	India's only ACTIVE volcano
Narcondam	Bay of Bengal	Dormant volcano
Lakshadweep	Arabian Sea	Entirely of CORAL origin (atolls)
Saddle Peak	N. Andaman	Highest point (~737 m)

■ STATIC THEORY

- The **Andaman Islands** are the extension of the Tertiary **Arakan Yoma** fold chain; main rocks are sandstone, limestone and shale (Majid).
- The **Nicobar** group (18 islands, 11 inhabited) is mainly of **coral origin**; the whole region lies in a **major earthquake zone**.
- **Barren Island** (Andamans) hosts **India's only active volcano**; **Narcondam** is dormant — both ~80 km east of the Andamans.
- **Lakshadweep** (Arabian Sea) is **entirely coral** (atolls) — the Indian illustration of Darwin's reef sequence.
- Coastlines here are dynamic: near the Ganga delta, islands appear and vanish with sea-level change (e.g. New Moore Island, Khullar).

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Andaman = Arakan Yoma extension (Tertiary), tectonic.
2. Nicobar = mainly coral origin (18 islands, 11 inhabited).
3. Barren Island = India's only active volcano; Narcondam = dormant.
4. Lakshadweep = entirely coral (atolls), Arabian Sea.

■ UPSC TRAPS

- ✗ Lakshadweep is volcanic like Barren Island.
- ✓ Lakshadweep is entirely CORAL (atolls); Barren Island is volcanic.
- ✗ The Andamans are of coral origin.
- ✓ The ANDAMANS are tectonic (Arakan Yoma extension); the NICOBARS are mainly coral.

5. A&N region lies in a major earthquake zone; Saddle Peak ~737 m.

✗ Narcondam is India's active volcano.

✓ BARREN Island is the active volcano; Narcondam is DORMANT.

■ MAINS ANGLE

Contrast the tectonic/volcanic Bay of Bengal islands with the coral Lakshadweep, and link their fragile ecology to strategic and conservation stakes.

■ STUDY LINK

Geography → India → Islands (Majid: A&N and Lakshadweep; Khullar: Islands/Tourism)

■ MEDIUM UPSC RELEVANCE

MEDIUM

CA ANCHOR — Great Nicobar (Galathea Bay) Mega-Project

GS-III • Indian islands applied → Development vs ecology

■ NEWS TRIGGER

The Great Nicobar mega-project plans an international transshipment port at Galathea Bay plus a township, airport and power plant — pitting strategic/economic gains against a fragile island ecosystem.

■ INTRO & ORIGIN

The project shows the tension between the Blue Economy/strategic connectivity and conserving a biodiversity-rich, tectonically active coral-and-rainforest island.

■ STATIC THEORY

- Components: **Galathea Bay transshipment port**, greenfield airport, township and power plant on Great Nicobar.
- Ecological concerns: dredging/reclamation threaten **coral reefs**, **leatherback turtle** nesting, coconut crabs and endemic species; the area is seismically active.
- Governance angle: Environmental Impact Assessment, CRZ clearances and tribal (Shompen/Nicobarese) rights.

■ MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Galathea Bay = proposed transshipment port on Great Nicobar.
2. Threatens coral reefs + leatherback turtle nesting sites.
3. Strategic value: near international shipping lanes / Malacca approaches.

■ UPSC TRAPS

✗ Great Nicobar is ecologically insignificant.

✓ It hosts coral reefs, leatherback nesting beaches and endemic species in a seismic zone.

■ MAINS ANGLE

Weigh strategic/blue-economy gains of Great Nicobar against irreversible ecological costs.

■ STUDY LINK

Geography → India Islands → Great Nicobar Project (applied CA)